Harry Baker Collection (from) The Sunshine Kid

By Harry Baker

INTRODUCTION

Author Harry Baker was recently asked in an interview: What does it mean to be interesting? His reply . . . For me it's about being different enough from the norm for people to sit up and take notice. It's not about purposefully trying to be quirky; it's more about being confident enough in who you are to not feel the need to dumb yourself down. And that's what his poem The Sunshine Kid is all about. The Sunshine Kid by Harry Baker

The Sunshine Kid

Old man sunshine was proud of his sun,

And it brightened his day to see his little boy run,

Not because of what he'd done,

nor the problems overcome,

But that despite that his disposition remained a sunny one.

It hadn't always been like this.

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There'd been times when he'd tried to hide his brightness,

Every star hits periods of hardship,

It takes a brighter light to inspire them through the darkness.

If we go back to when he was born in a nebula,

We know that he never was thought of as regular,

Because he had a flair about him,

To say the Midas touch is wrong but all he went near seemed to turn a little bronze,

Yeah this sun was loved by some more than others,

It was a case of Joseph and his dreamcoat and his brothers

Standing out from the crowd had its pros and its cons,

And jealousy created enemies in those he outshone

Such as the Shadow People.

Now the Shadow People didn't like the Sunshine Kid,

Because he showed up the dark things the Shadow People did,

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And when he shone he showed the places where the
Shadow People hid,
So the Shadow People had an evil plan to get rid of him,
First up – they made fun of his sunspots,
Shooting his dreams from the sky, their words were
gunshots,
Designed to remind him he wasn't very cool
And he didn't fit in with any popular kids at school.
They said his head was up in space and they would bring
him down to earth,
Essentially he came from nothing and that is what he
was worth,
He'd never get to go to university to learn,
Only degrees he'd ever show would be the 1st degree
burns
From those that came too close, they told him he was
too bright,
That's why no-one ever looked him in the eye,
His judgement became clouded and so did the sky,
With evaporated tears as the sun started to cry.

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The sunshine kid was bright, with a warm personality,
but inside he burned savagely –
Hurt by the words and curses of the shadowy
folk who spoke holes in his soul and left cavities,
and as his heart hardened,
his spark darkened,
Every time they called him names it cooled his flame,
He thought they might like him if he kept his light dim
But they were busy telling lightning she had terrible aim,
He couldn't quite get to grips with what they said,
So he let his light be eclipsed by what they said,
He fell into a Lone Star State like Texas,
And felt like he'd been punched in his solar plexus.

That's when Little Miss Sunshine came along
Singing her favorite song
about how we're made to be strong,
And you don't have to be wrong to belong,
Just be true to who you are,
because we are all stars at heart.
Little miss sunshine was hot stuff –

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The kind of girl when you looked at her you forgot stuff,
But for him, there was no forgetting her,
The minute he saw her, her image burned in his retina,
She was out of this world, and she accepted him,
Something about this girl meant he knew whenever she
    was next to him,
Things weren't as dark as they seemed,
and he dared to dream,
Shadows were nowhere to be seen;
when she was there he beamed,
His eyes would light up in ways that can't be faked,
When she grinned her rays erased the razor-tipped
    words of hate,
They gave each other nicknames
they were 'cool star' and 'fun sun',
And gradually the shadowy damage became undone,
She was one in a septillion,
and she was brilliant,
Could turn the coldest blooded reptilian vermillion,
Loved by billions,
from Chileans to Brazilians,

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And taught the Sunshine Kid the meaning of resilience.

She said:
"All the darkness in the world cannot put out the light of
    a single candle,
So how the hell can they handle your light?
Only you can choose to dim it,
and the sky is the limit,
so silence the critics
by burning."
If eyes are windows to the soul then she drew back the
    curtains
And let the sunshine through the hurting.
In a universe of adversity two stars stuck together,
And though day becomes night the memories last
    forever,
Whether the weatherman said it or not, it would be fine,
'Cause even behind the clouds the kid could still shine.
The Sunshine Kid was bright, with a warm personality,
And inside he burned savagely,

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Fueled by the fire inspired across galaxies,

By the girl who showed him belief.

TRANSITION

Now let's take that same small concept and expand it to society as a whole. 'Paper People' is one of Harry Baker's most successful poems, particularly because it takes the extended metaphor of a paper world and combines it with notions relevant to modern politics and current affairs. Paper People by Harry Baker.

Paper People

I like people.

I like some paper people.

They'd be purple paper people.

Maybe pop up purple paper people.

Proper pop up purple paper people.

'How do you prop up pop up purple paper people?'

I hear you cry. Well I…

I'd probably prop up proper pop up purple paper people

with a proper pop up purple people paperclip,

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but I'd pre-prepare appropriate adhesives as alternatives,

a cheeky pack of blu tack just in case the paper slipped.

I could build a pop up metropolis.

but i wouldn't wanna deal with all the paper people politics.

paper politicians with their paper-thin policies,

broken promises without appropriate apologies.

there'd be a little paper me, and a little paper you,

and we'd watch paper TV and it would all be paper view.

we'd watch the poppy paper rappers rap about their paper package

or watch paper people carriers get stuck in paper traffic on the A4.

There'd be a paper princess Kate but we'd all stare at paper Pippa,

and then we'd all live in fear of killer Jack the paper ripper.

cause the paper propaganda propagates the people's prejudices,

papers printing pictures of the photogenic terrorists.

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There'd be a little paper me, and a little paper you,
but in a pop up population people's problems pop up too.
there'd be a pompous paper parliament who remained out
of touch,
and who ignored the people's protests about all the
paper cuts,
then the peaceful paper protests would get blown to
paper pieces,
by the confetti cannons manned by pre-emptive police.
and there'd still be paper money, so there'd still be
paper greed,
and the paper piggy bankers pocketing more than they
need.
purchasing the potpourri to pepper their paper
properties,
while others live in poverty and ain't acknowledged
properly,
a proper poor economy where so many are proper poor,
but while their needs are ignored the money goes to big
wars,
funding origami armies building paper planes

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while we remain imprisoned by our own paper chains,
and the greater shame, is that we always seem to stay
the same,
what changes is who's in power choosing how to lay the
blame,
they're naming names, forgetting these are names of
people,
cause in the end it all comes down to people.

I like people. cause even when the situation's dire,
it is only ever people who are able to inspire,
and on paper – it's hard to see how we all cope,
but in the bottom of pandora's box there's still hope,
and i still hope cause i believe in people.

People like my Grandparents. who every single day
since i was born have taken time out of their
morning to pray for me.
that's 7433 days straight of someone checking i'm okay
and that's amazing.
people like my aunt who puts on plays for prisoners.

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people who are capable of genuine forgiveness.
people who go out of their way to make your life better
and expect nothing in return.
people have potential to be powerful.
and just because the people in power tend to pretend to
be different, we don't all need to
succumb to the system.
a paper population is no different.
there'd be a little paper me and a little paper you,
and we could watch paper TV and it would all be paper
view,
and in a pop up population people's problems pop up too
but even if the whole world fell apart then we'd still
make it through
because we're people.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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